departmental strength. The best college in a given stream may not have the top department in a specific subject, and vice versa. To help students navigate this, in 2023, we introduced a category for Best Colleges in Individual Subjects. In 12 disciplines across the arts and sciences—ranging from Economics and English to Chemistry and Sanskrit—we now assess departments based on objective data submitted by colleges.

The entire process rests on a granular evaluation of each college across five key parameters: 'Intake Quality and Governance', 'Academic Excellence', 'Infrastructure and Living Experience', 'Personality and Leadership Development' and 'Career Progression and Placement'. This metric of transparency helps students make informed choices based not just on reputation but on measurable outcomes.

One of the most pressing concerns for students and parents is the return on investment. What does a degree from a particular college translate into in terms of jobs and salaries? Our survey has been addressing this directly, highlighting colleges that offer the best placement packages, highest salary offers and lowest fees, allowing aspirants to balance aspiration with affordability.

1,865
No. of colleges that participated this year compared to 988 in 2018

India in 2025 stands at a demographic crossroads. With the world's largest youth population, the country has a fleeting window to convert its demographic dividend into economic gains. But this will only be possible if the young are educated and employable. A major concern is the low employability of graduates, with some recent estimates suggesting that fewer than half are job-ready.

Encouragingly, there is now a growing consensus that 'business as usual' is no longer enough. The convergence of political intent (as reflected in the National Education Policy 2020), technological disruption and societal demand for better learning outcomes has created a unique opportunity for systemic transformation. As has the disruption that US president Donald Trump is visiting upon American universities and their foreign students. At this momentous turn of history, the India Today Best Colleges Survey can both be a mirror and a map, a ready reckoner that charts where India's higher education stands today, and where it is headed tomorrow. It's not just a list. It's a tool for reform, reflection and renewal. ■

METHODOLOGY

How the Colleges were Ranked

With over 58,000 colleges across India, this 29th annual edition of India Today Group's ranking of colleges in India intends to make critical career decisions easier for aspirants based on rich information and data. This ranking has come to be known as the gold standard for other stakeholders such as recruiters, parents, alumni, policy makers, public and institutions. Since 2018, this survey has been conducted in association with reputed Delhi-based market research agency Marketing & Development Research Associates (MDRA) and has been widely appreciated for its consistency. Colleges were ranked across 14 streams—Arts, Science, Commerce, Medical, Dental, Engineering, Architecture, Law, Mass Communication, Hotel Management, BBA, BCA, Social Work and Fashion Design.

During objective ranking, MDRA carefully attuned more than 112 performance indicators in each stream to provide the most comprehensive and balanced comparisons of colleges. These indicators were clubbed into five broad parameters—'Intake Quality and Governance', 'Academic Excellence', 'Infrastructure and Living Experience', 'Personality and Leadership Development' and 'Career Progression and Placement'.

Moreover, to give more realistic, relevant and accurate information, MDRA evaluated colleges based on current year data. The ranking tables also give parameter-wise scores to provide deeper insights into key aspects of decision-making by various stakeholders. In addition, from 2023, the survey has come out with the first-ever ranking of colleges in major subjects, such as Economics, History, English, Psychology, Sociology, Political Science, Physics, Chemistry, Botany, Zoology, Hindi and Sanskrit based on the objective data submitted by the colleges.

The ranking was done in multiple steps

↘ An extensive desk review of MDRA's database and secondary research was conducted to prepare a list of colleges in each stream. Only those colleges which have been offering full-time, in-classroom courses and churned out at least three pass-out batches till 2024 were considered. In 12 streams, undergraduate courses were ranked. In Mass Communication and Social Work, post-graduate courses were evaluated.

↘ Experts with rich experi-